4NG Fanatics

Blue Front

By Martha Collins

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 3)** He was five.

He sold fruit. People came

came to see him

TOGETHER: make change

ACTOR 2: He sold

fruit on the street

came to see him

TOGETHER: make change

USE ONLY

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Martha Collin's father, as a five-year-old boy, sold fruit in front of the Blue Front Restaurant in Cairo, Illinois, in November 1909.*

ACTOR 2: *What he witnessed there and then, along with the reported 10,000 spectators, is shocking.*

TOGETHER: *Blue Front by Martha Collins*

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 14)** Welcome to Cairo

ACTOR 2: **(Pg 4)** the street was Commercial

ACTOR 1: Dowling Pressing

ACTOR 2: Saloon Drugstore Opera House

ACTOR 1: Three States Buggy Champion Tools

TOGETHER: Blue Front Restaurant

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 5)** a town where people lived

ACTOR 2: together black and white

ACTOR 1: **(pg 64)** Eleven White churches

ACTOR 2: Eleven black churches

ACTOR 1: **(pg 5)** couldn't look out the same window

ACTOR 2: couldn't read the same books

ACTOR 1: laundry couldn't be washed

in the same machines

ACTOR 2: water came from the same source

ACTOR 1: but couldn't be drunk

from the same fountain

ACTOR 2: **(pg 13)** couldn't be sworn in on the same Bible

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 28)** couldn't read the same books read only the others' old

ACTOR 2: couldn't be served in restaurants only backdoor take-out kitchens

ACTOR 1: couldn't swim in the swimming pool or skate at the skating rink

ACTOR 2: **(Pg 8)** Springfield in 1908

ACTOR 1: [247 miles away and a year earlier]

ACTOR 2: a black was accused of killing a white

ACTOR 1: another black of raping a white

ACTOR 2: a mob finding the prisoners gone burned the transporting car

TOGETHER: destroyed

ACTOR 1: 24 black businesses

ACTOR 2: 40 black homes

ACTOR 1: killed 2 successful black and also

TOGETHER: accidentally

ACTOR 2: 4 whites

ACTOR 1: in 1908 events occurred that led a 1909 Cairo paper to say its citizens *were*

ACTOR 2: *not moved by race prejudice, nor did they permit themselves to be led into wanton destruction of property, or the taking of innocent lives, as in Springfield*

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 9)** my father he sold

fruit on the street

ACTOR 2: **(pg 16)** he sold fruit in front

of the Blue Front

ACTOR 1: he was five

TOGETHER: he could make change

ACTOR 2: **(pg 10)** someone must have held

him up his uncle

ACTOR 1: his father's

shoulders

TOGETHER: so he could see

ACTOR 2: **(Pg 17)** 10,000 including children on parents' shoulders

ACTOR 1: who saw what occurred in November 1909

ACTOR 2: *(next 8 lines in newscaster's voices)* **(Pg 19)** it is supposed that

ACTOR 1: it is believed that Miss Anna Pelly

ACTOR 2: Miss Annie Pelley

ACTOR 1: Miss Anne

ACTOR 2: Miss Pelly age 24

ACTOR 1: age 22

ACTOR 2: who worked

In the Pupkin Dry Good store and lived

ACTOR 1: an orphan who lived with her married sister

ACTOR 2: **(Pg 9)** my father (**Pg 19)** was five

ACTOR 1: would not have seen

ACTOR 2: he could have known the little girl who found

TOGETHER: the body

ACTOR 1: she was seven

ACTOR 2: or three

ACTOR 1: but that would not have been till the next day

ACTOR 2: *(next 9 lines in newscaster's voices)* It is supposed she was assaulted on Elm

near her home

ACTOR 1: it is believed she struck **(Pg 20)** her assailant

ACTOR 2: who gagged *with such cruel force*

ACTOR 1: it is thought he carried her into the alley

ACTOR 2: the ground showed she was dragged

ACTOR 1: it is known she was outraged

ACTOR 2: *not a doubt*

ACTOR 1: and strangled

ACTOR 2: *a virgin unquestionably pure*

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 21)** said him because she was large

ACTOR 2: and he was larger he was large enough

ACTOR 1: said him because she was white

ACTOR 2: and he was black and could have therefore

ACTOR 1: must have necessarily

TOGETHER: him . . . . because

ACTOR 1: Was what they said it always was

ACTOR 2: was **why** they said they had to

TOGETHER: must

ACTOR 1: but it wasn't always rape

ACTOR 2: (alleged)

ACTOR 1: it wasn't always murder

ACTOR 2: (alleged)

ACTOR 1: it wasn't always even alleged

ACTOR 2: **(Pg 22)** bloodhounds got the scent
from the flour-sack cloth found
in the mouth

ACTOR 1: led authorities to Poplar Street

ACTOR 2: then more hounds

ACTOR 1: more to the same place

ACTOR 2: and later all the way to the city jail

ACTOR 1: Where Will 'Froggie' James

ACTOR 2: Will the Frog

ACTOR 1: Will alias Frog
who drove for Cairo Ice and Coal

ACTOR 2: Who stayed with Loving Green

ACTOR 1: who stayed with Georgia Cooper

ACTOR 2: To Poplar Street the house of Loving

ACTOR 1: Lovey

ACTOR 2: Lovie Green a negress of

TOGETHER: bad repute

ACTOR 1: where James stayed she was found
Washing a cloth that exactly matches

ACTOR 2: no . . . a similar cloth

ACTOR 1: Will James was arrested while driving his wagon

ACTOR 2: **(Pg 23)** no scratches blood

ACTOR 1: no missing items

ACTOR 2: But Anna Pelley's sister said
he delivered ice last summer

ACTOR 1: he was insolent

ACTOR 2: she had complained

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 44)** he was seventeen

ACTOR 2: once too he could have gone
to school Sumner High

ACTOR 1: (colored)

ACTOR 2: had been in town since the 1883 protests

ACTOR 1: But we do not know
if he went to school

ACTOR 2: above average intelligence
says a 1910 book but adds

TOGETHER: for one of his race

ACTOR 1: (*in newscaster's voice)* **(Pg 23)** authorities are taking extraordinary
precautions

to protect their prisoners because excitement
is high in all parts of Cairo

ACTOR 2: **(Pg 3)** [My father] was five. **(Pg 32)** he wouldn't have seen the train
make an extra stop for the prisoner
who was spirited away from jail
and into the sheriff's hands

ACTOR 1: mutterings of lynchings heard all day

ACTOR 2: would he have heard?

TOGETHER: there may be a lynching tonight

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 33)** at nine the mob went to the city
jail they searched the cells wooden and steel
struck matches threatened to lynch the police
chief and jailer if they would not produce

ACTOR 2: the mob was composed almost entirely of strangers

TOGETHER: **(Pg 32)** there may be a lynching tonight

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 38)** hang

As a mirror on a wall, or the fall
of a dress.
to fasten to dry.

ACTOR 2: so the act of doing it
changes the verb, tense not
quite right.

ACTOR 1: With rope, like a swing
from a tree, from a pole, like a flag

ACTOR 2: In the night,

ACTOR 1: in the air

ACTOR 2: **(Pg 50)** the victim hanged, though not on a tree

ACTOR 1: There were trees on those streets

ACTOR 2: trees that shaded the fenced-in yards of the large Victorian houses

ACTOR 1: trees that were known to the crowd

ACTOR 2: Not on a tree

ACTOR 1: they used a steel arch
with electric lights, and later a lamppost, this
was a modern event,

TOGETHER: the trees were not involved.

ACTOR 2: **(Pg 51)** a crowd waited at Union Depot four
doors down from the Blue Front

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 9)** my father he sold
fruit on the street

ACTOR 2: **(pg 16)** he sold fruit in front
of the Blue Front

ACTOR 1: **(pg 51)** the prisoner
dragged to Eight and Commercial

ACTOR 2: would his father and uncle
have carried him

ACTOR 1: joined men women and children

ACTOR 2: **Overlap** (women and children) filled from side
to side the entire width of the 100-foot street

ACTOR 1: a wild rush

ACTOR 2: flashes of gunfire

ACTOR 1: shouts

TOGETHER: Would he have understood

ACTOR 2: as they neared the arch
10,000 people massed together
a great angry wave of humanity shouted

ACTOR 1: 'You dog! You black brute! Kill him! Burn him!'

TOGETHER: Would he have understood

ACTOR 2: **(pg 52)** when someone turned on the lights on the arch
flooding the street the victim the crowd

ACTOR 1: He would have clearly seen

ACTOR 2: When they raised the victim
when the rope broke and the living body fell

TOGETHER: he would have seen

ACTOR 1: when they dragged the victim fifty feet
shot 500 bullets into him

ACTOR 2: dragged him heavy
to throw to the river but changed their minds

TOGETHER: He would have seen

ACTOR 1: When a woman lit the fire
while the crowd danced and shrieked

ACTOR 2: And while the body was burning they cut
off the half-burnt head

ACTOR 1: cut open the chest cut
out the heart for souvenirs

TOGETHER: He would have seen

ACTOR 2: When they placed the half-burnt head in a park
on a hitching post /

ACTOR 1: a tire stick / a pole

TOGETHER: He would have seen **(pg 55)**

ACTOR 2: he was five

ACTOR 1: **(pg 59)** Children were often there they were being taught.

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ACTOR 2: [The Belleville Illinois News Democrat reported it this way on November 12, 1909]

ACTOR 1: *(next 5 lines in newscaster's voices)* In ferociously dramatic fashion the infuriated populace staged a tragedy.

ACTOR 2: The pent-up fountains of human passion, human resentment, and human revenge broke forth.

ACTOR 1: A so-called mob outbreak is as much a magnificent and grand natural phenomena as a cyclone or an earthquake, or a thunderbolt or a flood is, and it is much more unerring, more just and more terrible.

ACTOR 2: The curtain has dropped. The band has ceased to play, the crowd is gone, the lights are out, the house is dark and it is over.

ACTOR 1: The outburst has done its work of purifying and of cleansing, and in that way it has fully accomplished its heaven-destined purpose.

ACTOR 2: **(pg 64)** Eleven White churches

ACTOR 1: Eleven black churches

ACTOR 2: Eleven white churches heard . . .

ACTOR 1: *(in a preacher's voice)* The failure of civil authorities to maintain law and order

ACTOR 2: *(in a preacher's voice)* the lynchings it seems were necessary
to arouse the people to startle

ACTOR 1: *(in a preacher's voice)* the worst class of criminal
is the criminal negro, the worst
creature on earth, the politician
has patted this class on the head as one
pats a dog but you would not pat a mad
dog with your hand, you would use a club

ACTOR 2: The papers did not record
what was said in eleven black churches

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 9)** my father he sold
fruit on the street

ACTOR 2: **(pg 16)** he sold fruit in front
of the Blue Front

TOGETHER: He would have seen

ACTOR 1: **(pg 55)** he was five

ACTOR 2: **(pg 77)** And the last day
ACTOR 1: [the day before my father died] he said
ACTOR 2: *(in the voice of the father)* You know
this would could be

A better place just

Promise me that you
will help
ACTOR 1: he waited

(pg 16) he sold fruit in front
of the Blue Front

TOGETHER: **(pg 77)** he made change

ACTOR 2: *(in the voice of the father as a little boy at the fruit stand)* may I help you please . . . . .

TOGETHER: make change

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AWARD HISTORY

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